chthonous tongues. This regional linguistic situation was being kept in mind by those who carved the inscriptions.

The form and content were also qualitatively different. Unlike the royal Buddhist convert of mainland India who took pains to explain his spiritual evolution, in Kandahar we see a remarkably self-assured emperor who has already converted others to his path. This message is not about his metamorphosis, it is a supremely confident summary of the sovereign's spiritual success:

> Ten years (of reign, or since the consecration) having been completed, king Piodasses (Piyadassi) made known (the doctrine of) Piety to men; and from this moment he has made men more pious, and everything thrives throughout the whole world. And the king abstains from (killing) living beings, and other men and those who (are) huntsmen and fishermen of the king have desisted from hunting. And if some (were) intemperate, they have ceased from their intemperance as was in their power; and obedient to their father and mother and to the elders, in opposition to the past also in the future, by so acting on every occasion, they will live better and more happily.[25]

This rescript was issued around the time of the edicts we have seen earlier. The differences between it and those are several: in his Kandahar message he relates no personal experience nor gives other reasons for propagating his doctrine of piety. He does not appear as a converted Buddhist. The confessional mode is omitted, as are the earlier moral expectations from administrators and subjects. The message is closer to being an announcement outlining the advent of a new era of general spiritual success following the tenth year of the king's consecration. In its tone it is similar to panegyrics extolling the successes of ancient conquerors, except, again, in the nature of the victory. The conquest proclaimed is now a promotion of piety which has enabled his subjects to live 'better and more happily.'

What of the character and quality of the language in this bilingual inscription—does it capture what constituted Ashoka's piety? One commentator, Paul Bernard, remarks on the excellence and contemporary nature of the Greek language which, as he puts it, does not give the